

Chop Wood Carry Water

How to Fall In Love With the Process of Becoming Great

Joshua Medcalf

The Question the Book Is Asking

How do you fall in love with the ordinary, repetitive, invisible work that greatness actually requires — when everything in you wants to skip to the result?

The Answer It Gives

You stop treating the work as a means to an outcome. The outcome is only partially yours; the person the work makes you is entirely yours. Detach your identity from your performance, replace society's scorecard with one you chose, commit fully to what you control, surrender the rest — and then chop wood and carry water, every day, no matter what is happening around you.

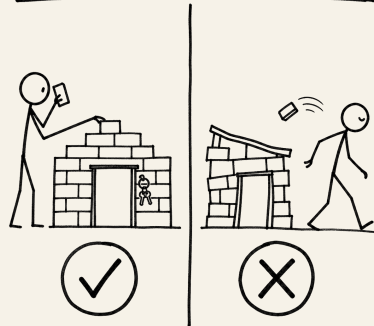
The Apprentice's Sequence

The book is one story: a young man named John spends ten years apprenticed to an old sensei named Akira, learning archery by chopping wood and carrying water. Each lesson arrives at the moment John's own resistance produces the need for it. That order is the argument.

- 01 Do the small work** — Everyone wants to be great until it is time to do what greatness requires.
- 02 Learn what you are actually building** — You are never working on the assignment. You are working on yourself.
- 03 Take your eye off the goal** — With one eye on the goal, you only have one eye for the journey.
- 04 Rebuild identity and scorecard** — Value comes from who you are; achievement is salt water.
- 05 Survive the enemies** — Discouragement, comparison, self-talk, and the edited lives of other people.
- 06 Trust how mastery moves** — In steps, not constants. Roots for years before height.
- 07 Surrender the outcome** — Gratitude, controllables, surrender, process.
- 08 Trade the goal for a mission** — A goal can be blocked. A mission cannot.

The Insights

BUILDING YOUR OWN HOUSE



INSIGHT 01

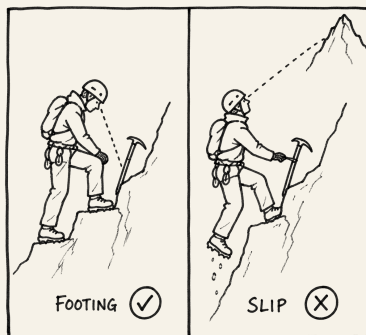
You Are Always Building Your Own House

Every day you are producing two things: the work, and the person doing the work. The work gets handed over, forgotten, or lost. The person is the only permanent output. Treat any assignment as something you are doing for someone else and you will quietly lower the standard, because the cost of lowering it seems to land on them.

Kota built the finest houses in Tokyo for thirty years, hand-selecting every material. Asked to build one last house before retiring, he agreed with his head but not his heart — he delegated, details slipped, the house passed code and nothing more. When he finished, his boss handed him a small box with the keys inside. It was his house. It had been his the whole time.

Before you cut a corner, ask who actually receives the cut. The answer is always the same person.

ONE EYE FOR THE JOURNEY



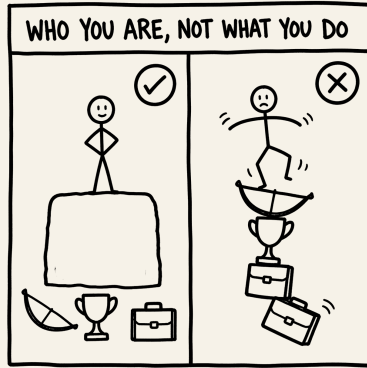
INSIGHT 02

With One Eye on the Goal, You Only Have One Eye for the Journey

Attention is not additive. Whatever you give the outcome comes out of the process, and the process is the only place the skill is actually built. A related trap: treating situations as tests. If it is a test, you optimize for passing it. If it is an opportunity, you optimize for what you take out of it. Over years those two people end up in different places.

John asks how long it will take to become a samurai archer. Ten years. And if he skips chopping wood and carrying water? Twenty. And if he gives every waking moment to archery alone? Thirty. Ice climbers who stare at the summit cannot see where to put a foot; they slip and they die.

Judge your day by whether you did the work well, not by where the work left you on the scoreboard.



INSIGHT 03

Your Value Comes From Who You Are, Not From What You Do

When identity is fused to performance, every result becomes a verdict on your worth — which inflates you when things go well, flattens you when they don't, and quietly corrupts your decisions, because now every choice is also a defense of your value. The fix is to locate identity in something that cannot be taken away in a moment.

John overtrains, tears his shoulder, and is put out of action for six to eight weeks. Akira asks him: you cannot shoot, you cannot chop wood or carry water — so who are you? John has no answer. Akira's own: I am not a samurai archer; I am a human being who happens to be world class at archery.

Answer the question now, in writing, while nothing has been taken away — because the day it is taken away is the worst day to start looking.

ACHIEVEMENT IS SALT WATER



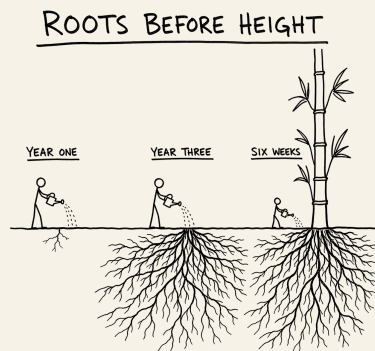
INSIGHT 04

Achievement Is Salt Water

Achievement does not fill the hole people expect it to fill; it enlarges the thirst. If what you have accomplished so far has not done the job, more of it will not do the job either. The society-issued scorecard — win more, earn more, be seen more — is not a hard scorecard to top. It is an impossible one, which is a different problem entirely.

Kobe Bryant says a sixth title will satisfy him and let him retire. Andre Agassi, after reaching number one in the world: "I thought that getting to number one was going to be the moment I made sense of my life. But it left me a little empty, and I spiraled down."

You need a scorecard of your own, made of characteristics rather than results, and you need to actually grade yourself on it.



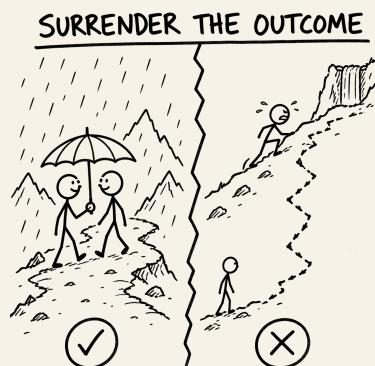
INSIGHT 05

Growth Happens Underground Long Before It Happens in the Air

Mastery moves in steps, not constants — long flat plateaus broken by sudden jumps. Feeling stuck is therefore not evidence of being stuck; it is the normal texture of the middle. And the invisible years are not wasted time before the growth. They are the structure that lets the growth hold.

Plant bamboo in good soil and water it faithfully and you see nothing for roughly five years — while underground a dense mat of roots spreads out to carry weight that does not yet exist. Then it comes up ninety feet in six weeks. Height without roots is the story of people who arrive at success and cannot hold it.

Measure the watering, not the height, and do not read a plateau as a verdict.



INSIGHT 06

Surrender the Outcome

Partially controllable goals — winning, sales, someone else's record — are alluring and dangerous, because pursuing them hard enough leaves a wake regardless of whether you arrive. Reaching the goal makes the wake easier to justify. It does not make it smaller. Surrender is not indifference; it is removing the one thing that makes you tight, forces your hand, and keeps you out of the moment.

Akira drives all day through Croatian mountains to reach a waterfall, snapping at the woman he loves, ignoring her when she says she only wants to spend the day with him, ignoring locals who warn him off the trail — and finally, in the dark and the rain, having sent her back down with strangers, he turns around without ever seeing it.

Name what you actually control, commit everything to it, and let the rest go before it costs you the people standing next to you.

Definitions and Distinctions

Talent vs. skill

Talent is what you have naturally. Skill is developed only by hours and hours of beating on your craft. Talent without skill fails you under pressure; the book treats heavy talent as closer to a curse, because it lets you skip the process that produces durability.

Goal vs. mission

A goal can be blocked by other people — checkpoints, gatekeepers, opponents. A mission is something you can do right where you are, with what you have, without anyone's permission. Only the person in the mirror can stop a mission.

Test vs. opportunity

Nothing is a test. A test is passed or failed; an opportunity is mined. The same hour of work yields very different returns depending on which one you think you are in.

Feelings vs. principles

Feelings move without warning. Principles do not. At the end of your feelings is nothing; at the end of every principle is a promise.

Guest vs. pest

The difference is an invitation. Wisdom delivered without one makes you an obstacle to the growth you were trying to cause.

The warrior dial

Your activation level from one to ten. One is stealth and stillness; ten is screaming. Precision work happens around four or five, and turning the dial down is a far harder skill than turning it up.

What to Actually Do

BUILD YOUR OWN SCORECARD

ACTION 01

Build Your Own Scorecard

List the people you genuinely admire and the characteristics they embodied that you would want to be known for. Narrow it to the four that matter most. Grade yourself on those four twice a day.

Set it up once. Grade at midday and again at night — midday so you still have an evening to correct what is slipping.

Any situation, including a bad one, becomes a place to move a number you chose yourself rather than one the world assigned you.

Caution. Four, not eight. A scorecard you cannot hold in your head is a list, not a scorecard.

WHAT WENT WELL

ACTION 02

Keep a What Went Well Journal

Write a worth statement at the top — my value comes from who I am, not from what I do — then a growth statement: anything that happens to me today is in my best interest and an opportunity to learn and grow. Then fifteen specific things you did well. Then, and only then, two areas for growth and two things you learned.

After every training session, performance, or working day.

Fifteen stops being hard. You start noticing good repetitions while they are happening rather than reconstructing them at night.

Caution. Two growth areas, never more — nobody can hold more than two in mind the next day. If you quit short of fifteen, beat yesterday's stopping point by two.

PRINCIPLES IN YOUR POCKET

ACTION 03

Carry Your Principles in Your Pocket

Each morning, before the work starts, write out four to six principles you will hold to no matter what. Fold the paper and put it in your pocket.

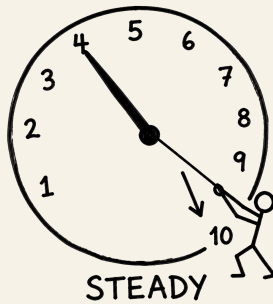
Daily, and especially on days you can already feel your mood making decisions for you.

When feelings surge, you touch the pocket or read the list aloud, and the decision is already made.

Caution. Borrow principles that have been tested for a long time rather than inventing clever ones. You will still slip; the practice is getting back on the road, not never leaving it.



THE WARRIOR DIAL



ACTION 04

Set Your Warrior Dial Before You Perform

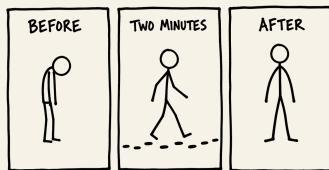
Notice where your activation sits on a one-to-ten scale, decide where it needs to be for this particular task, and move it deliberately. Down: slow breathing, slower speech, lower voice, slower movement, calm music. Up: upbeat music, movement, anything that fires you.

In the minutes before anything that requires precision — and before the games that feel too big, which is exactly when everyone overshoots.

You arrive at the line at your number instead of whatever number the occasion handed you.

Caution. Turning the dial down is much harder than turning it up, and most training cultures only ever practice up.

TWO MINUTE GRATEFULNESS WALK



ACTION 05

Take the Two-Minute Gratefulness Walk

Walk for two minutes naming everything you are grateful for, with deliberate attention on the things you normally take for granted.

Immediately after a loss, a bad session, or any moment you notice perspective has gone.

You can feel the shift inside two minutes — and you are markedly easier to be around for the people who have to live with your result.

Caution. It works as a reset, not as a substitute for the reckoning. Do the walk, then have the honest conversation about what went wrong.

QUICK REFERENCE

THE INSTRUCTION

Chop wood, carry water — no matter what is happening around you.

THE STAKE

You are always building your own house.

THE TRAP

With one eye on the goal, you only have one eye for the journey.

THE REFRAME

Nothing is a test. Everything is an opportunity to learn and grow.

THE IDENTITY

My value comes from who I am, not from what I do.

THE THIRST

Achievement is salt water. Grade yourself on a scorecard you chose.

THE DARK

You do not shine under the bright lights. They only reveal your work in the dark.

THE THIEF

Comparison steals all joy. The grass is greener where you water it.

THE VOICE

Talk to yourself instead of listening to yourself.

THE ROOTS

Five years underground, then ninety feet in six weeks.

THE GROUND

At the end of your feelings is nothing. At the end of every principle is a promise.

THE COMPASS

Trade the goal for a mission. No one can stop you from living a mission.

THE POSTURE

Gratitude. Controllables. Surrender the outcome. Trust the process.